

Teaching International Economic Law after Generative AI and Geoeconomic Fragmentation

A Source-Centred, Comparative and Simulation-Based Model for Legal Education

Abstract

Legal education is not facing a single technology problem. It is facing a double disturbance in the relation between legal knowledge, legal work and legal judgment. Generative artificial intelligence makes polished written work a less reliable proxy for the student's own research and reasoning. At the same time, geoeconomic fragmentation has changed the substance of fields such as International Economic Law (IEL), where sanctions, export controls, industrial policy, investment screening, data sovereignty, carbon border measures and supply-chain security now sit alongside the classical law of trade, investment and international finance. This article develops a reflective, source-grounded case study of the redesign of "International Economic Law and Relations" (LW6167E), a postgraduate course at the School of Law, City University of Hong Kong. It argues that advanced legal education should move from an "AI-proofing" mentality to a model of epistemic apprenticeship: students should learn how legal knowledge is produced, verified, compared, challenged and defended under contemporary conditions. The proposed "two-lane-plus" model combines a secure individual lane for verified doctrinal competence, an open AI-integrated lane for supervised collaborative research, and a performance lane of oral simulation and defence. The article's original contribution is to connect assessment design with the changing legal order itself. AI-resilient legal education should not merely protect academic integrity. It should train source literacy, responsible AI practice, comparative and geopolitical reasoning, and public defence of legal judgment.

Keywords

Generative AI; legal education; international economic law; Chinese law; Hong Kong legal education; geoeconomics; assessment; comparative law; source literacy; TWAIL

1. Introduction: The Wrong Question about AI

The most familiar institutional question about generative artificial intelligence in legal education has been defensive: how can law teachers prevent students from submitting AI-generated work as their own? The concern is real. A modern chatbot can produce a plausible legal essay, memorandum, policy brief or case note with little visible evidence of the underlying process. The product may be fluent, organized and apparently authoritative. It may also be shallow, fabricated, jurisdictionally imprecise or quietly wrong. The difficulty is therefore not limited to plagiarism. It is evidential. A take-home text no longer reliably proves that the named student performed the research, interpretation, comparison and judgment that the assessment claims to measure.

That problem is acute in law because legal education has long treated written work as evidence of more than writing. An essay is expected to show doctrinal knowledge, source selection, legal interpretation, argument structure, professional judgment and intellectual independence. Generative AI weakens that evidential chain. It does not make writing irrelevant. It makes final prose insufficient. If the assessment is designed as though the submitted document alone can carry the burden of proof, the design is now fragile.

International Economic Law (IEL) faces a second disruption. The subject matter itself has become less settled. A late twentieth-century version of the field could be taught, at least in simplified form, as a project of multilateral liberalization, investment protection, institutionalized dispute settlement and technical rule application. That account was always partial, but it has become still less adequate. Contemporary IEL is increasingly shaped by the weaponization of economic interdependence, WTO dispute-settlement paralysis, U.S.-China strategic competition, sanctions, export controls, investment screening, industrial subsidies, digital trade conflicts, data localization, artificial intelligence governance, carbon border adjustment and renewed contestation over development and sovereignty.¹

These two disruptions interact. AI changes how students can produce legal work. Geoeconomic rivalry changes what competent legal work must understand. A student may ask a model to summarize GATT Article XXI and still fail to grasp why national security has become a central legal vocabulary of technology rivalry. A student may generate a comparison of EU, U.S. and Chinese data governance and still miss how each model reflects different constitutional commitments, state capacities, industrial strategies and geopolitical anxieties. A student may submit polished prose on carbon border adjustment and still be unable to defend a position when challenged by a peer representing a developing state, an exporter, a regulator, an investor or a tribunal.

This article argues that advanced legal education should respond by redesigning curriculum and assessment around source-centred, comparative and performative legal judgment. The proposal is neither to ban AI nor to surrender learning to AI. It is to make AI use visible, accountable and educationally productive while preserving secure spaces in which individual legal competence can still be verified.

The article develops this argument through a case study of the redesign of LW6167E, "International Economic Law and Relations", a postgraduate English-medium course at the School of Law, City University of Hong Kong. The redesigned course replaces a conventional individual written assignment with a supervised group research project, an AI Usage and Methodology Statement, oral presentation and simulation, peer evaluation and a controlled final examination. It also reframes the syllabus from a largely trade-law-centred course into an inquiry into IEL in a geoeconomic world, placing WTO law, investment law, international finance and digital trade alongside sanctions, export controls, supply-chain resilience, digital currencies, state capitalism, carbon border measures, the Belt and Road Initiative, and Global South perspectives.²

The article makes four contributions. First, it reframes generative AI as an epistemic challenge to legal assessment rather than merely a misconduct problem. Second, it specifies a law-specific "two-lane-plus"

assessment architecture: secure individual verification, open AI-integrated research, and live professional defence. Third, it contributes to comparative and Chinese legal education scholarship by showing how Chinese and Hong Kong legal materials can be taught as part of contested global legal ordering, not merely as domestic context or exceptional case. Fourth, it argues that source infrastructure itself is pedagogy: curated corpora, primary materials, AI-use protocols and oral defence routines teach students how legal knowledge is made.

2. Dual Disruption: AI and Geoeconomic Legal Order

2.1 Generative AI and the evidential failure of final prose

Generative AI has exposed a weakness that was already present in legal education. Take-home written assessment has always been incomplete evidence of learning. It may show the final arrangement of claims, but it tells us less about how the student found sources, distinguished primary authority from commentary, checked factual claims, tested counterarguments, managed uncertainty, collaborated with others or revised under critique. AI intensifies this problem because it can produce the appearance of competent legal prose without the student having performed the corresponding intellectual labour.

The developing literature on AI and legal education supports this point. John Bliss argues that legal education should prepare students for professional environments in which generative AI will be embedded in legal research, drafting and communication, while also training them to evaluate AI outputs and reflect on responsible use.³ The empirical literature makes the assessment problem concrete. Choi, Hickman, Monahan and Schwarcz found that ChatGPT could produce passing work across law school exams, though with uneven quality. Alimardani's study of criminal law examination performance likewise showed that AI-generated answers could be assessed credibly by markers unaware of their origin, even while revealing weaknesses in legal depth and precision. More recent work on automated exam grading suggests that large language models can approximate or assist some aspects of grading when supplied with rubrics, while leaving significant ethical, institutional and professional questions unresolved.⁴

These studies should not be read to mean that AI can replace legal judgment or legal teachers. Their importance is different. They show that legal educators can no longer assume that a submitted text is strong evidence of the student's own process. The central assessment question must therefore shift from "Can AI do this task?" to "What must the student visibly do, verify and defend in order for this task to count as legal education?"

Professional ethics reinforces the same conclusion. The American Bar Association's Formal Opinion 512 does not treat generative AI as an ethical vacuum. It places AI use within ordinary professional obligations of competence, confidentiality, communication, candor, supervision and reasonable fees.⁵ UNESCO's guidance for generative AI in education and research similarly emphasizes policy design, human agency, privacy, inclusion and critical validation.⁶ For law schools, the implication is direct: AI literacy is not only a technical skill. Students must learn when a tool is appropriate, what information may

be entered, how outputs must be verified, what use should be disclosed, and when human judgment is non-delegable.

2.2 Geoeconomic fragmentation and the changing substance of IEL

IEL remains doctrinally grounded in treaties, institutional practice, cases and principles. Students still need to understand GATT Articles I, III, XI, XX and XXI; the SCM Agreement; GATS; investment treaty standards; dispute settlement; monetary and financial institutions; and the relationship between domestic regulation and international economic obligations. Yet the field can no longer be taught convincingly as a stable technical architecture of liberalization.

Farrell and Newman show how networked global economic structures can become instruments of coercion when states control key hubs and chokepoints.⁷ Post-neoliberal trade law scholarship likewise argues that international trade law must now confront development, inequality, state capacity, democratic contestation and the return of industrial policy rather than assume a universal policy preference for market liberalization.⁸ These arguments have pedagogical consequences. Students need doctrinal discipline, but they also need to understand how states frame legal arguments as security, resilience, industrial strategy, environmental protection, privacy, development or sovereignty.

The challenge is especially important in Hong Kong and Chinese legal education. Chinese law is not merely a domestic body of rules to be taught apart from the international economic order. Chinese legal materials increasingly operate inside global contestation: WTO accession and disputes, trade remedies, data governance, cyber-sovereignty, export controls, foreign investment regulation, state-owned enterprises, national security, the Belt and Road Initiative, digital currency and debates about foreign-related rule of law. Scholarship on Chinese legal education has emphasized globalization, legal transplant, comparative training, practical skills and the need to prepare foreign-related legal talent.⁹ The AI and geoeconomic moment extends that agenda. Students must learn to analyze Chinese law and policy as both domestic legal material and as a set of positions within transnational regimes.

2.3 The missed opportunity in "AI-proofing"

Many immediate responses to generative AI have focused on academic integrity: detection, prohibition, declarations, invigilation and punishment. Integrity rules remain necessary. But if the central question is only "How can we stop students from using AI?", legal education misses the deeper opportunity. The more important question is: what forms of legal work should students now be required to perform so that AI becomes an object of critical practice rather than a substitute for learning?

The two-lane approach to assessment, developed and discussed in universities such as Sydney and Auckland, offers a useful starting point. It distinguishes controlled assessment that verifies student attainment from open assessment that helps students learn in environments where AI and other tools are available.¹⁰ But law requires a discipline-specific version. Legal work is not only written production. It is source selection, interpretation, advising, negotiation, advocacy, drafting, ethical decision-making and

public defence. A legal version of two-lane assessment should therefore include a performance element in which students must speak, respond, justify and revise in real time.

3. From Assessment Security to Epistemic Apprenticeship

This article uses the term "epistemic apprenticeship" to describe a learning design in which students are trained not only to state legal conclusions but to show how legal knowledge is produced. The phrase is useful because it shifts attention from the polished answer to the disciplined process behind it. In an epistemic apprenticeship, students learn to ask: What is the relevant legal authority? What source can support this claim? What is the difference between treaty text, case law, state practice, institutional commentary, scholarship, news reporting and AI output? What jurisdictional assumption is being made? What geopolitical position does this legal argument occupy? What would a reasonable opponent say? What must be disclosed about method?

The model proposed here has three features.

First, it is source-centred. Legal education should require students to connect claims to legal authority and to distinguish levels of authority. AI can summarize, translate, organize and suggest, but students must verify. A chatbot answer is not a legal source. At most, it is a starting point for investigation.

Second, it is comparative. Contemporary IEL problems are rarely single-system problems. Data flows require comparison of EU, U.S., Chinese and regional models. Investment screening requires comparison of domestic security review, treaty protections and arbitral standards. Carbon border adjustment requires comparison of climate policy, WTO non-discrimination, development claims and industrial strategy. Comparison is not ornament. It is method.

Third, it is performative. Legal judgment must be defended before others. Oral simulation, negotiation, tribunal argument, client briefing and peer questioning expose whether students can move beyond prepared prose. They also make AI's role more honest. AI may help a student prepare, but it cannot itself perform the live professional act of answering a challenge.

This model draws on older legal education insights. The Carnegie Report criticized legal education for over-privileging analytical thinking while under-integrating practical skill and professional identity. Best-practices and clinical scholarship similarly emphasizes active, contextual and reflective learning.¹¹ Generative AI does not make those insights obsolete. It makes them more urgent.

4. Methodology and Case Context

This article is a reflective, source-grounded case study. It does not claim to measure learning gains through a controlled empirical design. It develops a theoretically informed account of a course redesign

based on documentary evidence, teaching practice and analysis of the kinds of work elicited by the redesigned assessment.

The sources include the 2025/26 LW6167E syllabus, continuous assessment instructions, group presentation schedule, selected student group reports and AI Usage and Methodology Statements, the author's Google Drive course folder for "International Economic Law and Relations", a NotebookLM corpus assembled for the teaching-law project, and a local source-centred research workspace built for this article.¹² Public scholarship on legal education, AI, Chinese legal education, comparative law, decolonial international law and geoeconomics supplies the conceptual frame.

The use of student materials is deliberately limited. The article refers to project topics, assessment design and recurring patterns in student reflection. It does not identify students by name, quote private student work at length or treat the materials as data from a formal human-subjects study. Any later submission using more detailed student quotation or performance claims should be checked against institutional ethics requirements. Here, student work is used to illustrate the pedagogical environment and the forms of learning activity produced by the redesign.

LW6167E is a postgraduate English-medium course at City University of Hong Kong. The 2025/26 syllabus describes it as a critical and comprehensive examination of IEL amid a paradigm shift in the global order. It remains grounded in the Bretton Woods institutions, WTO law, international finance and investment, but gives substantial attention to geoeconomic competition, technological disruption and the green transition. Its intended learning outcomes include comprehension of IEL across trade, investment, finance and data movement; interpretation of legal texts and cases; understanding of international economic organizations and dispute settlement; analysis of the relation between national regulation and international economic law; engagement with cutting-edge issues; and independent research using advanced legal technologies, including AI.¹³

The assessment structure already contains the seed of a two-lane design. Continuous assessment accounts for 40 percent: a 30 percent research project or equivalent coursework component and 10 percent class participation. The final examination accounts for 60 percent. Where university facilities are available, the examination is conducted in computer labs with access to files, programs and the internet blocked.¹⁴ The redesign described below strengthens that separation and gives it a more explicit pedagogical logic.

5. The Two-Lane-Plus Model

The redesigned course uses a "two-lane-plus" architecture. The first lane verifies individual competence under controlled conditions. The second lane supports open, supervised, collaborative and AI-aware research. The "plus" is live professional performance: students must defend their work orally, respond to questions and inhabit legal positions in simulation.

Component	Assessment function	AI position	Legal-educational purpose
Controlled final examination	Verifies individual doctrinal competence and analytical reasoning	Restricted or unavailable under controlled conditions	Ensures that each student can reason without delegating core legal analysis
Collaborative research project	Develops authentic legal and policy research in an open environment	Permitted, disclosed and audited through an AI Usage and Methodology Statement	Builds research, collaboration, source verification and responsible AI practice
Oral simulation and Q&A	Tests live professional performance and public defence	May assist preparation but cannot substitute for real-time response	Develops advocacy, negotiation, strategic judgment and ability to answer challenge
Peer evaluation and supervision	Creates accountability and formative correction	AI use becomes part of the process conversation	Reduces free-riding, surfaces errors and supports reflective learning

This architecture changes the meaning of the written report. The report remains important, but it is no longer asked to carry the whole evidential burden. It becomes one element in a chain of work: topic selection, source gathering, legal mapping, AI experimentation, verification, supervision, presentation, peer questioning and final reflection.

The model also develops four literacies. Source literacy requires students to distinguish primary legal materials, institutional documents, state communications, scholarship, policy reports, media sources and AI summaries. AI verification literacy requires students to disclose AI use, explain prompts or workflows where relevant, and verify output against legal sources. Comparative and geopolitical literacy requires students to understand that legal arguments are made from positions: the same data-transfer rule, subsidy, tariff, screening decision or carbon measure looks different from the perspective of China, the United States, the European Union, a developing country, an investor, a regulator or a tribunal. Oral professional literacy requires students to translate research into live performance.

The "plus" therefore matters. Two-lane assessment can distinguish controlled from open tasks, but law teaching should go further. Lawyers must speak, listen, negotiate, answer hostile questions, manage uncertainty and revise advice. Oral simulation re-centres those capacities and prevents AI from being treated as a complete substitute for professional judgment.

6. Rebuilding the Syllabus: IEL as a Geoeconomic Laboratory

The syllabus redesign is not merely a change of topics. It changes the implicit theory of the field. The older course model, reflected in earlier documents, emphasized WTO doctrine, trade remedies, dispute settlement, regional trade agreements and conventional legal analysis. The 2025/26 syllabus retains those foundations but places them within a broader account of economic order under stress.¹⁵

In the reformed model, IEL is taught as an argumentative field in which doctrine, power and institutional design interact. Students still need to know treaty rules and legal techniques. But they also need to understand why those rules are invoked in disputes over semiconductors, electric vehicles, digital services, investment screening, climate transition, critical minerals and monetary infrastructure. The legal question is rarely only "what does the rule say?" It is also "why is this actor invoking this rule now, what alternative characterization is available, and what institutional forum can make the characterization matter?"

This design makes geoeconomic rivalry a subject of legal education rather than background noise. It also makes comparative law unavoidable. A digital trade problem may require comparison of the EU's rights-based data protection model, the U.S. sectoral and national-security model, and China's cyber-sovereignty, data security and personal information regimes. An investment screening problem may require comparison of CFIUS, EU foreign direct investment screening, Chinese national security review and treaty-based investor protection. A carbon border problem may require comparison of EU climate policy, WTO non-discrimination rules, Global South development claims and domestic industrial policy.

For Chinese legal education, this shift is significant. Comparative legal education in and about China has often been framed through globalization, legal transplant, professional skills or domestic reform. Those remain important. But the geoeconomic era asks a more relational question: how do Chinese legal positions, institutions and strategies interact with other legal orders in contested global regimes? The point is neither to present Chinese law as derivative of Western models nor to treat it as so exceptional that ordinary comparative method cannot apply. The point is to train students to locate Chinese law within the legal struggles through which global economic order is now being made.

7. The Group Project: From Assignment to Apprenticeship

The continuous assessment instructions ask students to identify and analyze a concrete contemporary issue in IEL and international relations faced by states, international organizations or multinational corporations. Suggested topics include the WTO dispute settlement crisis, unilateral tariffs, economic sanctions, export controls, semiconductor restrictions, GATT Article XXI, ISDS reform, foreign investment screening, green transition, cross-border data flows, digital service taxes, AI regulation in trade agreements, CBAM, green subsidies and climate finance disputes.¹⁶

The deliverables are layered. Each group submits a report of up to 5,000 words, an AI Usage and Methodology Statement of up to 500 words, a one-hour in-class presentation followed by Q&A, and peer evaluation. The AI statement is central. It prevents AI from being either forbidden magic or invisible labour. Students must disclose how AI tools were used for brainstorming, research, drafting, editing or translation; what prompts or methods were used where relevant; and how outputs were verified against primary legal sources.¹⁷

The supervision loop turns the assignment into apprenticeship. Rather than receiving a topic, disappearing for weeks and submitting a final essay, groups present topics, outlines, source maps, preliminary arguments and AI-use reflections during the process. The instructor can intervene when students rely on hallucinated authorities, misread treaty provisions, confuse policy documents with law, overstate news reports, or treat AI summaries as authority. This feedback is not merely corrective. It teaches how legal knowledge is made.

The design also responds to unequal AI benefits. AI may help students enter unfamiliar fields by supplying initial explanations, generating issue maps, translating dense materials, suggesting counterarguments or organizing an outline. It may also harm learning when students accept fluent output without understanding. Student reports and methodology statements from the course show both tendencies. Some groups used AI productively for topic exploration, preliminary structuring, language support and debate rehearsal. The same materials also reveal recurring needs for deeper doctrinal specificity, more direct use of treaty text and cases, clearer separation of law from policy, and more flexible oral response.¹⁸ That pattern supports the central claim of this article: AI-integrated legal learning must be supervised, source-linked and performed.

8. Student Projects as Evidence of a New Pedagogical Field

The presentation schedule and student reports show a striking range of contemporary IEL problems: China-EU countervailing duties on electric vehicles, supply-chain disruption, cross-border data flows among China, the United States and the European Union, carbon border adjustment, China-EU digital taxation, U.S. tariffs on China, White Plan and Keynes Plan debates, WTO DS611 and the MPIA, critical minerals, U.S.-China trade policy review, the Northwest Passage, DS641 Canada tariff-rate quotas, the Dutch takeover of Nexperia, reciprocal tariffs and investment arbitration simulations.¹⁹ These topics are not random. They represent a field in transition.

8.1 Trade disputes and geoeconomic statecraft

The trade-disputes cluster required students to confront the instability of WTO legalism in an age of national security. Projects on U.S. tariffs, Canada tariff-rate quotas, China-EU electric vehicle countervailing duties and semiconductor-related measures required students to map the difference between ordinary protectionism, industrial policy, supply-chain security and security exceptions. Students could not simply recite non-discrimination. They had to ask whether a formally neutral measure has discriminatory effects, whether a tariff surcharge violates bound rates, whether a quota functions as a quantitative restriction, and how Article XXI should be read after recent national-security disputes.

The pedagogical value of this cluster lies in the movement from doctrine to strategy. Legal argument in IEL is not merely syllogistic. It is also narrative and institutional. States frame themselves as rule defenders, victims of protectionism, guardians of national security, protectors of industrial resilience or

representatives of development interests. In a U.S.-China trade policy review simulation, for example, student teams debated data governance, technology subsidies, intellectual property, agricultural product safety and rare earth resources. The report reflected an awareness that each side needed legal claims, agenda control, evidence, counter-narrative and rhetorical discipline.²⁰

8.2 Investment screening and strategic sectors

The investment cluster exposed students to the tension between investor protection and public regulatory authority. Traditional investment law teaching often begins with fair and equitable treatment, expropriation and investor-state arbitration. The reformed course keeps those concepts but situates them in a world of national security screening, strategic sectors and green transition. Students must ask how investment law responds when states screen foreign investment in semiconductors, energy infrastructure, data platforms or critical minerals; when climate policy disrupts investment expectations; or when investor protection collides with public interest regulation.

This is a comparative-law exercise. It requires students to compare treaty standards, domestic screening mechanisms, arbitral reasoning and political economy. It also helps them see that "regulatory autonomy" is not a slogan. It is a legal and institutional problem that depends on treaty text, domestic authority, evidence of public purpose, proportionality, compensation rules and the credibility of state explanation.

8.3 Digital trade, data governance and AI sovereignty

The digital-economy cluster is especially valuable for teaching Chinese law, comparative law and international law together. Cross-border data-flow disputes require students to compare legal models: EU data protection and fundamental rights; U.S. sectoral, market-oriented and national-security approaches; Chinese data security, personal information protection, cyber-sovereignty and important-data regimes. Students must also understand how digital trade chapters in agreements such as CPTPP, USMCA and DEPA structure the vocabulary of data movement, localization and exceptions.

AI makes this cluster more complex. Data is both regulated object and productive input. States therefore treat data governance as trade policy, industrial policy, national security policy and rights policy at once. The same legal measure can be characterized as privacy protection, market access restriction, cybersecurity, censorship, industrial strategy or digital sovereignty depending on viewpoint. The educational aim is not to force students into one characterization. It is to train them to identify the legal consequences of competing characterizations.

8.4 Climate, carbon borders, critical minerals and the Global South

The climate and sustainability cluster connects trade doctrine with distributive justice. CBAM projects require students to analyze most-favoured-nation treatment, national treatment, border adjustment, Article XX environmental exceptions, development concerns and the relation between climate policy and industrial strategy. Critical minerals projects require analysis of export controls, resource conservation,

supply-chain security, green transition and the strategic value of rare earths. These are no longer peripheral topics. They increasingly define the legal politics of the global economy.

This cluster also opens the door to TWAIL and decolonial approaches. Scholarship on decolonizing the international law curriculum asks legal educators to examine how dominant knowledge hierarchies are reproduced through teaching.²¹ Recent TWAIL commentary on AI governance similarly warns that AI can reproduce structural inequality through data extraction, infrastructure dependence and regulatory models shaped by the Global North.²² When students study CBAM, data governance, AI regulation or critical minerals, they should therefore ask who benefits from a rule, who bears compliance costs, whose evidence counts and whose legal arguments are treated as universal rather than positional.

9. Original Contribution: A Legal Pedagogy of Verification, Comparison and Defence

The article's original contribution is not the claim that teachers should use group work, oral presentations or AI declarations. Those devices already exist in many institutions. The contribution is to show why, in advanced legal subjects, they should be integrated as a legal pedagogy of verification, comparison and defence.

First, the article reframes the AI challenge as an epistemic problem. Academic integrity rules remain necessary, but they cannot by themselves produce legal competence. The real task is to design learning environments in which students must show how legal knowledge is made: how sources are found, how AI outputs are tested, how uncertainty is handled, how law is compared across systems and how claims are defended before others. A task is not educationally valuable simply because AI performs it poorly. Nor is a task educationally valueless because AI can assist with it. The key question is whether the task requires visible, assessable legal judgment.

Second, the article develops a legal version of the two-lane model. The basic distinction between secure and open assessment is useful, but law needs performance. A discipline-specific model should combine secure doctrinal verification, open source-centred research and live professional defence. Depending on the course, the performance lane may take the form of oral examination, negotiation, tribunal argument, client advice, treaty drafting, mediation, policy briefing or simulation. In each form, students must show that they can move from prepared materials to responsive judgment.

Third, the article treats comparison as a method rather than ornament. In a geoeconomic IEL course, comparison is not a supplementary foreign example. It is how the subject is understood. Students cannot analyze digital trade without comparing data governance models. They cannot analyze investment screening without comparing domestic security review regimes and treaty protections. They cannot analyze Chinese trade policy without comparing U.S., EU, WTO and Global South positions. Comparative law becomes the discipline of seeing how legal claims shift as institutional setting, political economy and state position change.

Fourth, the article links AI literacy to professional and ethical formation. Responsible AI use requires more than prompt skill. It requires competence, confidentiality, candor, supervision, disclosure, verification and judgment about when not to use a tool. This is especially important in international and comparative law, where models may overgeneralize, fabricate citations, flatten jurisdictional difference, reproduce dominant-language bias or miss recent legal developments.

Fifth, the article identifies source infrastructure as pedagogy. The project used a Google Drive corpus, NotebookLM source collection and local research workspace to curate materials for teaching-law research. Such infrastructure matters. If students use general chatbots in a vacuum, they may learn prompt fluency without source discipline. If they work from curated but contestable source collections, they can learn how arguments depend on evidence. The future of AI in legal education is therefore not simply the insertion of chatbots into existing assignments. It is the construction of governed, source-aware learning environments.

10. Risks, Limits and Conditions for Transfer

The model is promising, but it is not costless. It requires supervision time, assessment design, rubrics and institutional support. Group work can produce free-riding unless peer evaluation and instructor oversight are meaningful. Oral simulation can reward confidence over substance unless questions and criteria are carefully designed. AI methodology statements can become formulaic unless teachers read them and discuss them. Controlled examinations can verify individual competence, but they cannot capture the full range of professional capacity.

Equity also matters. Students may have unequal access to high-quality AI tools, different language backgrounds, different confidence in oral performance and different familiarity with global legal sources. A source-centred AI design should therefore include shared materials, transparent expectations, options for students who choose not to use particular AI tools, and clear rules about what may not be uploaded to external systems.

Privacy and confidentiality are especially important in law. If students upload unpublished student work, confidential course materials or sensitive facts into external AI systems, legal and institutional risks may arise. Legal education should therefore teach not only how to use AI but where not to use it and what must not be entered. That lesson connects student practice to professional duties.

The case-study method is another limitation. This article does not quantify learning gains, compare grades before and after the redesign or report systematic student interviews. Future research should do so. A stronger empirical study could analyze AI methodology statements, compare quality of source use across cohorts, evaluate oral performance, interview students about AI and geopolitical learning, and test whether the model improves retention, transfer and professional confidence.

The model must also be adapted by field. A first-year contract course, a Chinese constitutional law seminar, an international arbitration clinic and an IEL course should not use identical designs. The transferable principle is the architecture: verified individual competence, open source-centred AI use, explicit methodology, iterative feedback, comparative positioning and live defence.

11. Conclusion: Teaching Judgment in a Fragmented and Automated World

Generative AI has made it easier to produce legal text and harder to know what that text proves. Geoeconomic rivalry has made legal subjects such as IEL more contested and harder to teach as stable doctrine. Together, these changes require more than policy statements about cheating or technology. They require curricular and assessment redesign.

The LW6167E reform offers one model. It treats AI not as an enemy of legal education but as a condition under which legal education must become more rigorous. It treats geopolitics not as a distraction from legal doctrine but as part of the world in which doctrine now operates. It treats Chinese law, comparative law and international law not as separate silos but as interacting sites of professional judgment.

The central lesson is demanding but straightforward: students should not be assessed only on the polish of a final text. They should be assessed on the quality of their sources, the transparency of their method, the discipline of their AI use, the accuracy of their legal analysis, the sophistication of their comparative positioning, the ethics of their professional choices and their ability to defend a judgment before others. In the age of AI and geoeconomic fragmentation, the task of legal education is not to preserve old assignments in more secure form. It is to teach students how to think, verify, compare and argue when both the tools of legal work and the world of legal order are changing.

References and Source Notes

1. Henry Farrell and Abraham L. Newman, "Weaponized Interdependence: How Global Economic Networks Shape State Coercion" (2019) 44(1) *International Security* 42; Yong-Shik Lee, "International Trade Law Post Neoliberalism" (2020) 68 *Buffalo Law Review* 413.
2. City University of Hong Kong, School of Law, "LW6167E International Economic Law & Relations Syllabus (Rev 2025-clean)" (August 2025), on file with author.
3. John Bliss, "Teaching Law in the Age of Generative AI" (2024) 64 *Jurimetrics Journal* 111.
4. Jonathan H. Choi, Kristin E. Hickman, Amy B. Monahan and Daniel Schwarcz, "ChatGPT Goes to Law School" (2023) 71(3) *Journal of Legal Education* 387; Armin Alimardani, "Generative Artificial Intelligence vs. Law Students: An Empirical Study on Criminal Law Exam Performance" (2024) 16(2) *Law, Innovation and Technology* 777; Kevin L. Cope, Jens Frankenreiter, Scott Hirst, Eric A. Posner, Daniel Schwarcz and Dane Thorley, "Grading Machines: Can AI Exam-Grading Replace Law Professors?" (2026) *Journal of Law and Empirical Analysis*, DOI: 10.1177/2755323X261434265.
5. American Bar Association Standing Committee on Ethics and Professional Responsibility, Formal Opinion 512, "Generative Artificial Intelligence Tools" (29 July 2024).
6. Fengchun Miao and Wayne Holmes, *Guidance for Generative AI in Education and Research* (UNESCO, 2023).
7. Farrell and Newman, above n 1.
8. Lee, above n 1.
9. Cecily E. Baskir, "Legal Education in China: Globalizing with Chinese Characteristics" (2015) 2(2) *Asian Journal of Legal Education* 143; Matthew S. Erie, "Legal Education Reform in China Through U.S.-Inspired Transplants" (2009) 59(1) *Journal of Legal Education* 60; Yuxia Song and Haotian Fan, "The 70 Years of Legal Education in China from 1949 to 2023: Historical Development, Current Issues and Future Innovations" (2024) 11(2) *Asian Journal of Legal Education* 201.
10. Adam Bridgeman and Danny Liu, "Frequently Asked Questions about the Two-Lane Approach to Assessment in the Age of AI" (Teaching@Sydney, 2 July 2024, updated 21 April 2026); University of Auckland, "Two-Lane Approach to Assessment" (TeachWell Digital, 2026).
11. William M. Sullivan, Anne Colby, Judith Welch Wegner, Lloyd Bond and Lee S. Shulman, *Educating Lawyers: Preparation for the Profession of Law* (Jossey-Bass, 2007); Roy Stuckey and others, *Best Practices for Legal Education: A Vision and A Road Map* (Clinical Legal Education Association, 2007).
12. Project sources include Google Drive, AC-Teaching/International Economic Law and Relations; NotebookLM notebook "Teaching Law"; and the local project source workspace "AI, Geopolitics, and Legal Education", all on file with author.
13. City University of Hong Kong syllabus, above n 2.
14. *Ibid.*
15. *Ibid.*
16. City University of Hong Kong, "IELR CA Assessment: Instructions and Requirements" (2025), on file with author.
17. *Ibid.*
18. Selected LW6167E student group reports and AI Usage and Methodology Statements (2025), on file with author.
19. City University of Hong Kong, "LW6167E: International Economic Law & Relations Presentation Schedule" (20 November 2025), on file with author.

20. Student group report, "The China-US Debate on the 2024 TPR" (2025), on file with author.
21. Michelle Burgis-Kasthala and Christine Schwobel-Patel, "Against Coloniality in the International Law Curriculum: Examining Decoloniality" (2022) 56(4) The Law Teacher 485.
22. Miracle Okoth Okumu Mudayi and Jake Okechukwu Effoduh, "TWAILing AI Governance: Will Third World Countries Be Left Behind?" (TWAILR: Reflections 74/2025, 7 August 2025).